

MSCI281 Assignment 1

Supply Chain Adaptability to External Shocks/Disruptions

Type:	Individual assignment
Weighting:	50% of final grade
Consultation moments:	Week 6 – Assignment briefing; discussion of ideas Week 10 – Assignment seminar Weeks 5-7, 9&10 – Consultation hour (Fridays, 10:00 – 11:00; request another appointment if you have class)
Consultation formats:	Class briefing session (week 6, 9:00 lecture) Assignment workshop (week 10 tutorial sessions) Individual consultation (drop in during consultation hour)
Word limit:	Maximum 3000 excluding appendices and references
Coursework Due Date:	12 January, 2024

Your Assignment

Gartner releases a list of top 25 supply chains every year. For the [Supply Chain Top 25 companies, 2022, Gartner](#) stated that the best-performing supply chains, among others “stabilise more quickly after external shocks”. In other words, they are highly adaptable.

In this assignment you must investigate a particular event as an external shock affecting supply chains and study how two different supply chains overcame the issues/ problems arising from the event. You may choose major events (e.g., the Covid-19 pandemic, extreme weather events, conflicts) or minor ones (e.g., the Suez canal blockage, UK rail strikes). You can find other examples in [this linked article](#)). You can select any aspect of Supply Chain Management but must focus on how and why the supply chains quickly stabilised after the

event. Did they make the same choices? Was there path dependence in the choices they made? The approach you adopt should be analytical and include lessons learned for supply chains in an increasingly turbulent environment.

Requirements

It is expected that you will:

- a) Provide an introduction that sets the scene, explains how the event you choose led to supply chain problems and why you chose it (i.e., how does it lead to a better understanding of how supply chains (can) stabilise more quickly after external shocks).
- b) Undertake a relevant critical literature review that helps to inform your investigation. The most obvious concept here is supply chain resilience, but you can choose another one that would also fit your chosen problem better (e.g., supply chain agility). You should base your literature review on your reading of selected journal papers in the supply chain, operations management and related literature. This should include, but not be limited to: key definition(s) of supply chain concepts associated with recovery/ stabilising aftershocks, how it is supposed to be achieved, its effects on performance, and whether being so adaptable is desirable under all circumstances. Bear in mind the quality of the sources you use, and aim to draw on about 10 journal papers.
- c) Identify two examples of supply chains affected by the event you have chosen; the bigger the differences between the supply chains (e.g., in terms of strategy or sector), the better. You should use company websites and other relevant industry sources to analyse how they overcame the effects of the event. Please be as specific as possible: what were the effects of the event on each supply chain, how did different supply chain partners play a role in finding a solution, did the supply chain fully recover, etc.?
- d) Use key concepts and insights from your literature review in Part (b) to analyse the cases in Part (c). Discuss whether and how the supply chains you select adapt/ stabilise quickly after a shock based on the concept(s) in your literature review. Make sure you compare the two cases. You should also discuss, with reference to relevant concepts from the module, the advantages and disadvantages for the organisations' decisions and actions. Based on this, provide recommendations for dealing with events like the one you select in general.

Supply Chain Selection & Analysis

Since Supply Chain Management is concerned with interorganisational relationships and how supply chain members function to deliver a product or service to a customer, you must ensure that you analyse the problem at the supply-chain level. You can choose a focal firm and then take a supply chain view on how it dealt with arising issues. For example, you can use some of the companies in the Gartner Top 25 list (see hyperlink in opening paragraph). If you want to explore COVID-19 related issues, follow this link for an example of the [Supply Chain Top 25 companies of 2019](#) for top-performing supply chains just before the pandemic. Details of Gartner's Top 25 methodology can be found [here](#).

I am interested in your analysis of the cases. This means that you should not merely reproduce or summarise existing discussions about them, but write your own analysis. You should also be sceptical and critical of the claims made by many of the industry sources you use – they are often trying to sell something (remember the marketing guy versus judge analogy I introduced during a week 4 lecture). You may also want to relate your discussion to key SCM topics covered on the module such as inter-organisational relationships, the bullwhip effect, trade-offs, and so on.

General Points

The word limit is 3000 words, excluding references and Appendices.

I strongly encourage the use of diagrams (e.g., supply network diagram) and Tables. However, use diagrams only where appropriate and either created or adapt/synthesise existing ones. In case of the latter, cite the original sources you adapted them from. Do not copy-paste diagrams without modification from any source.

Figures and Tables must have numbers and titles, and you should refer to them explicitly in your text. Appendices should be used only for material that is not required by the reader to follow the argument of your essay (i.e., for optional, background material). Any material placed in the Appendix will be considered “nice to see” and may not be graded.

Academic Practice

Please use subheadings clearly to indicate the structure of your work. Use a consistent method of referencing, preferably the Harvard system. You are referred to the Lancaster University Library pages regarding referencing and plagiarism: <https://www.lancaster.ac.uk/library/how-to/reference/>

Please don't plagiarise; it is a serious academic offence. All work submitted will be analysed by plagiarism detection software. Using AI to generate your assignment is not allowed. So, plagiarism detection will also capture AI-use. However, you may use it for other purposes, e.g., grammar tools. For any AI used, please include an Appendix to your assignment specifying which tools you use, how, and for what purpose.

Submission & Consultation

Please submit the work electronically via Moodle. The submission date is **12 January 2024**. The exact time will be evident from the Moodle submission tool.

Please do not put your name on your work or in the filename, only your student ID number.

Please discuss the assignment with me if you require clarification. You can use the specified consultation moments, come up to me after class, or book an appointment if you have schedule clashes.

Dr Nonhlanhla Dube (n.dube@lancaster.ac.uk)

